

EXPLORING GOD'S WISDOM IN PROVERBS

May 13, 2026

Desire vs. Expectation

 Proverbs 11:23–25  Greg Granger**INTRO** Introduction

Tonight, we are going to begin by looking at two different manifestations of the human heart condition. A heart that is set on righteousness, and a heart that is set on wickedness, and their respective results.

SCRIPTURE Desires and Outcomes**Proverbs 11:23**

The desire of the righteous ends only in good, the expectation of the wicked in wrath.

Let's break this down one step at a time.

a. The “desire” of the righteous: We all “long” for something. That longing is our hearts desire. Can we begin tonight by simply asking ourselves one simple question?

b. What is the desire of my heart?

For some, it could be comfort. For others, it could be money. For yet another, it could be food. Some people, church, might desire to spend more time with family and friends than they do with God and His people. So, ask yourself, when you lay there in bed at night - what do you look FORWARD to happening, or long for?

c. Any “desire” of your heart that is not “of God” is an opportunity to grow in your personal holiness, and communion with Christ.

APPLICATION Application

When we look at Proverbs 11:23 in the ESV, it tells us, "The desire of the righteous ends only in good, the expectation of the wicked in wrath." This verse is really getting at the ultimate trajectory of our motives, and to really understand what this looks like in practice, I think of the story of Daniel and the corrupt administrators in Babylon.

Daniel was a man whose deepest desire was simply to remain faithful to God and to serve his king with integrity. He didn't seek power through manipulation; his motives were pure and righteous. Even when that righteous desire landed him in a terrifying situation...being thrown into a den of hungry lions for refusing to stop praying. This proverb held true. Because his foundation was rooted in trusting God, his story ended entirely in good. He was pulled from the den without a single scratch, his faith was vindicated, and he was ultimately promoted.

On the flip side, you have the corrupt officials who orchestrated the whole trap. Their expectation was entirely wicked. Out of pure jealousy, they hoped to destroy an innocent man just to secure their own political power or gain.

Admittedly, for a brief moment, it probably looked to them like their wicked plot had succeeded when the king was forced to have Daniel arrested. But the proverb reminds us that the expectation of the wicked ends only in wrath, and their selfish ambition completely backfired.

The very trap they set for Daniel became their own demise, and they faced immediate, absolute destruction when the king threw them into the lions' den instead. It's a powerful reminder that while wicked intentions might seem to win in the short term, a righteous heart is the only thing that leads to a truly good and lasting outcome.

INTRO Introduction to v24

Now, we move from examining the deep motives of our hearts to looking at how those motives manifest in our hands. Specifically, how we handle the resources God has entrusted to us. We are going to look at the striking difference between the world's economy and God's economy.

The world says, "keep what you have to get rich." God says something entirely different.

SCRIPTURE Generosity vs. Greed

Proverbs 11:24 (ESV)

One gives freely, yet grows all the richer; another withholds what he should give, and only suffers want.

- a. The paradox of giving freely: It defies basic human math. We assume that subtracting from our bank account or our pantry leaves us with less. But in God's kingdom, open-handed generosity actually leads to spiritual, and sometimes physical, abundance.
- b. The danger of withholding: We hold tightly to our money, our time, and our energy out of fear. We think, "If I give this away, I won't have enough for me." So, ask yourself honestly: Are you living life with an open hand, or a closed fist?
- c. Any time we tightly grip our resources out of fear or greed, we miss an opportunity to trust God as our ultimate Provider and to be a conduit of His blessing.

APPLICATION v24 Application

When we look at Proverbs 11:24 in the ESV, it tells us, "One gives freely, yet grows all the richer; another withholds what he should give, and only suffers want."

This verse highlights the incredible paradox of Kingdom economics, and to really understand what this looks like in practice, I think of the contrasting story of the parable of the Rich Fool.

Jesus tells a parable in Luke 12 about a Rich Fool. This man had a harvest so abundant that his current barns couldn't hold it. Instead of seeing this surplus as an opportunity to give freely and bless his community, his expectation was entirely self-centered. He chose to withhold what he could have given, tearing down his barns to build bigger ones just so he could hoard his wealth and live a life of lazy comfort.

For a brief moment, it probably looked to him like his strategy of hoarding had secured his future. But the proverb reminds us that withholding what we should give only leads to want. That very night, God required the man's soul, leaving his hoarded wealth to others. He entered eternity completely bankrupt. It's a powerful reminder that while hoarding might make us feel secure in the short term, holding our lives and resources with an open hand is the only way to experience true, lasting abundance in Christ.

SCRIPTURE The Cause of Quarrels and Fights**James 4:1–10 (ESV)**

1 What causes quarrels and what causes fights among you? Is it not this, that your passions are at war within you? 2 You desire and do not have, so you murder. You covet and cannot obtain, so you fight and quarrel. You do not have, because you do not ask. 3 You ask and do not receive, because you ask wrongly, to spend it on your passions. 4 You adulterous people! Do you not know that friendship with the world is enmity with God? Therefore whoever wishes to be a friend of the world makes himself an enemy of God. 5 Or do you suppose it is to no purpose that the Scripture says, "He yearns jealously over the spirit that he has made to dwell in us"? 6 But he gives more grace. Therefore it says, "God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble." 7 Submit yourselves therefore to God. Resist the devil, and he will flee from you. 8 Draw near to God, and he will draw near to you. Cleanse your hands, you sinners, and purify your hearts, you double-minded. 9 Be wretched and mourn and weep. Let your laughter be turned to mourning and your joy to gloom. 10 Humble yourselves before the Lord, and he will exalt you.

Sometimes, we do not have because we do not ask.

Perhaps even if we asked, we wouldn't receive, because God knows intimately the desires of your heart...so He knows exactly how you will steward every single blessing that He gives, realized, and unrealized.

INTRO Introduction to v25

Following right on the heels of the paradox of generosity in verse 24, verse 25 takes us a step further. It shifts our focus from simply the resources we give away, to the refreshment we bring to others. It is about the culture of our lives and relationships. Are we life-givers, or are we life-drainers?

SCRIPTURE The Reciprocity of Blessings**Proverbs 11:25**

Whoever brings blessing will be enriched, and one who waters will himself be watered.

- a. The calling to bring blessing: A literal translation of the Hebrew phrase here is a "soul of blessing." This isn't just about handing someone money; it's about a continual disposition of the heart. Ask yourself: Do people walk away from conversations with you feeling encouraged, built up, and blessed?
- b. "One who waters will himself be watered": This is the beautiful, reciprocal promise of God's kingdom. When you feel dry, the world says to isolate, turn inward, and focus entirely on yourself. God says, go find someone else who is thirsty and pour into them. As you water them, God promises to water your own soul.
- c. Any time we choose to criticize, tear down, or stubbornly isolate ourselves, we miss the profound joy of being spiritually refreshed by the hand of God. We were designed to be conduits of grace, not bitter reservoirs.

APPLICATION**Application**

When we look at Proverbs 11:25 in the ESV, it tells us, "Whoever brings blessing will be enriched, and one who waters will himself be watered." This verse perfectly highlights the spiritual law of encouragement. To really understand what this looks like in practice, I think of the life of a man in the New Testament named Joseph—though you probably know him by his apostolic nickname, Barnabas, which literally means "Son of Encouragement."

Barnabas was a man whose entire ministry was defined by "watering" others. When the Apostle Paul was a brand-new convert, the other disciples in Jerusalem were terrified of him. They thought his conversion was a trap. But Barnabas stepped in, brought blessing, and advocated for Paul when no one else would. Later, when a young John Mark abandoned a mission trip and Paul wanted to cast him aside, it was Barnabas who took John Mark under his wing, watering the soul of a young man who felt like a failure.

Did Barnabas lose out by constantly pouring his time and energy into the messy lives of others? Not at all. Because he chose to water others, his own life and legacy were incredibly enriched. Paul went on to write half the New Testament, and John Mark went on to write the Gospel of Mark! Barnabas's life was deeply enriched because he lived as a "soul of blessing."

It's a powerful reminder that when we feel empty, dry, or sidelined, the answer isn't to look inward. The answer is to look around, find someone who needs encouragement, and start watering. In God's perfect design, the very act of pouring out His love onto others is exactly how He pours fresh grace back into us.

TRANSITION**Scripture Reading**

"Preach the gospel to yourself every day before you preach it to anyone else." - Martin Luther King Jr.

PRAYER POINTS**Point 1: Growth in Holiness and Communion with Christ**

Pray that Trinity Baptist Church and its Members would walk daily with God, and grow in personal holiness and communion with Jesus Christ.

Point 2: Deepened Trust in God's Word

Pray that Trinity Baptist Church and its Members would study the Scripture daily and grow in the depth of their trust in God's Word.

Point 3: Cultivating Generosity

Pray that Trinity Baptist Church and its Members would cultivate a spirit of radical generosity, holding their worldly possessions loosely and using them to bless others.

Point 4: Deepened Trust in God's Provision

Pray that Trinity Baptist Church and its Members would break free from the fear of lack, choosing instead to trust fully that God will supply all their needs according to His riches in glory.

Point 5: Becoming a Church of Encouragement

Pray that Trinity Baptist Church and its Members would be known as "souls of blessing" in their homes, workplaces, and community, actively seeking ways to encourage, uplift, and refresh the people around them.

Point 6: Refreshment for the Weary

Pray that those in the church who are currently feeling spiritually dry, burned out, or exhausted would step out in faith to "water" someone else this week, and in doing so, experience the promised, supernatural refreshment of the Holy Spirit in their own lives.

Point 7: Models of Love

Pray that Trinity Baptist Church and its Members would be models of the love of Christ in every situation, gathering, and interaction.